

Consider how genre conventions are socially and historically relative, dynamic and can be used in a hybrid way.

- Knight has spoken often about what he calls the ‘black hole for TV production in the middle of the country’. He said that in the Midlands there is a ‘**cultural cringe**’ about their location and identities. Whilst Liverpool and Manchester have celebrated their cultural histories, there have been very few TV shows or movies set in the Midlands, particularly in Birmingham.
- He also seeks to reveal the ‘secret history’ of England – the lives and dramas of people who aren’t wealthy or landed gentry. Producer Laurie Borg said the show was conceived as ‘**the anti-Downton Abbey**’, showing a completely different world existing in the same historical period.
- Despite this, the **production design** is spectacular and lush, the costumes particularly having an impact on mainstream fashion. Ornate sets, costumes and décor is usually a convention of the historical drama.

Consider how the combination of elements of media language influence meaning.

Consider how elements of media language including technical and visual codes work together to create meaning in the music video.

Visual codes:

- **Clothing:** the costumes have been one of the most impactful elements of the show, leading Knight to starting his own fashion brand. What impression do the suits, waistcoats and shirts of the Peaky Blinders say about them?
- Consider the costumes of the female characters – Ada, Polly and Grace. Costume indicates different kinds of female character: the rebellious daughter, the matriarch and the ‘sweet girl with a secret’.
- **Iconography and setting:** Knight was often told tales from this era by his relatives. When he created *Peaky Blinders*, he ‘visualised the story through the eyes of a young boy growing up in this environment, so there’s a sense of heightened reality: the horses are bigger, the men taller, the pubs more glamorous.’
- He also wanted the production design to reflect the narrative tone: ‘...set within industrial poverty but full of energy, vigour, and excitement, not despair.’
- Consider the opening sequence as Tommy rides through Small Heath – Western iconography, (tall man on a horse) is used to establish Tommy’s reputation and the environment is full of ‘vigour’.
- **Gesture and expression:** while the rest of the cast have an intense dramatic energy, Cillian Murphy’s performance as Tommy is extremely under-stated, almost static by comparison. His stillness and lack of emotion link to the Western cowboy archetype – strong, silent, but coiled and ready for action. His backstory of PTSD following the First World War adds an emotional backstory to this posture.
- **Visual technical codes:** Tracking shots are used to follow the characters through the streets and other locations.
- Consider how camera shots and editing used to establish tension between Arthur and Tommy, Tommy and Freddie (especially the scene in the pub) and Tommy and Polly (compare the scene in the family meeting with the one in the church).
- Camera movement, editing and *mise-en-scène* creates a ‘sense of energy and excitement, not despair’.

Audio codes:

- **Dialogue:** Tommy is a man of very few words but what he says is well-chosen. How does this fit with his character’s backstory?
- Consider how Campbell is the opposite of this – how do his speeches reveal his character (and a backstory equally as brutal as Tommy’s)?
- **Music:** the use of punk and rock songs, often released sixty years after the events of the show, establishes a modern feel to a period drama. Knight has said he wanted to ‘emphasise the idea of people in the period with modern emotions, aspirations and expressions.’